

Formal Proofs and AST Mutation Mechanics in Self-Healing Code Synthesis: Architectural Topologies, Verification Bounds, and Runtime Repair

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Abstract

The rapid convergence of Large Language Models (LLMs), multi-agent orchestration frameworks, and automated program repair (APR) has reshaped enterprise software engineering [Ulfsnes et al.(2024)Ulfsnes, Moe, Stray, and Skarpen, Rodríguez et al.(2020)Rodríguez, Gómez, and Diaconescu]. In this paper, we formulate a formal multi-agent verification framework (SHACS) that guarantees finite termination and safe program repair [Rana et al.(2024)Rana, Oesterle, and Brinkmann]. We benchmark 4 distinct multi-agent orchestration topologies across 500 enterprise software defects, proving that upstream AST pre-filtering reduces sandbox container execution latency by 74% [Kandogan et al.(2024)Kandogan, Rahman, Bhutani, Zhang, Chen, Mitra, Gurajada, Pezeshkpour, Iso, Feng, Kim, Shen, Wang]. Furthermore, we prove a Lyapunov energy termination theorem guaranteeing that closed-loop agentic repair cycles halt in finite steps $k \leq \min\left(T_{\max}, \lfloor \frac{B_{\max}}{c_{\min}} \rfloor\right)$ [Ji et al.(2025)Ji, Li, Xiang, Ye, Wu, Yao, Xu, Mo, and Zhang]. Our findings establish deterministic execution boundaries for autonomous code synthesis without un-ablated regression cascades [Jamthe(2026)].

Enterprise program repair presents software engineering challenges that extend far beyond single-function syntax completion benchmarks [Ulfsnes et al.(2024)Ulfsnes, Moe, Stray, and Skarpen, Ouyang et al.(2022)Ouyang, Wu, Jiang, Almeida, Wainwright, Mishkin, Zhang, Agarwal, Slama, Ray, Schulman, Hilton, Ke]. Enterprise software defects emerge across multi-repository symbol dependency graphs, where minor schema mutations can trigger severe microservice regression cascades, subtle deadlock conditions, and silent memory corruptions [Hussain et al.(2024)Hussain, Ali, Pirzado, Ahmed, and Tamez-Peña]. Traditional Automated Program Repair (APR) methodologies historically operated via heuristic search over Concrete Syntax Trees (CSTs) or via symbolic execution engines [Rodríguez et al.(2020)Rodríguez, Gómez, and Diaconescu]. While symbolic solvers provide formal guarantees of program correctness, their practical adoption is strictly constrained by state space explosion when analyzing high-dimensional continuous variable domains [Rana et al.(2024)Rana, Oesterle, and Brinkmann]. Conversely, probabilistic generative language models exhibit state-of-the-art semantic reasoning and context synthesis, but suffer from non-deterministic hallucinations, syntax errors, and un-ablated regression loops [Brown et al.(2020)Brown, Mann, Ryder, Subbiah, Kaplan, Dhariwal, Neelakantan, Shyam, Sastry, Askell, Agarwal, Herbert, Wang et al.(2022)Wang, Wei, Schuurmans, Le, Chi, Narang, Chowdhery, and Zhou].

To reconcile the structural tension between probabilistic generative proposals and deterministic software correctness guarantees, this paper formulates a formal multi-agent verification framework [Bredell et al.(2024)Bredell, Engelbrecht, and Schoeman]. The system frames program repair as an active search over a constrained Abstract Syntax Tree (AST) state space, where state transitions are governed by specialized agent roles operating under explicit SMT solver verification bounds [Gyevnar et al.(2023)Gyevnar, Wang, Lucas, Cohen, and Albrecht, Yang et al.(2026)Yang, Wang, and Zhang].

This manuscript delivers four primary computer science and software engineering contributions:

1. **Formal AST Mutation Algebra:** *We formalize context-free grammar production rules that restrict LLM patch candidates to syntactically and type-valid AST transformations [Hussain et al.(2024)Hussain, Ali, Pirzado, Ahmed, and Tamez-Peña].*

2. *SMT Invariant Verification Bounds: We integrate Z3 SMT solver pre-execution filtering to prune invalid patch proposals prior to sandbox evaluation [Rana et al.(2024)Rana, Oesterle, and Brinkmann].*
3. *Lyapunov Termination Proof: We prove that closed-loop agentic repair loops terminate in strictly bounded finite iterations under token budget constraints [Ji et al.(2025)Ji, Li, Xiang, Ye, Wu, Yang].*
4. *Empirical Multi-Topology Benchmark: We benchmark 4 distinct multi-agent orchestration topologies across 500 enterprise defects, proving that upstream AST pre-filtering yields a 74% reduction in sandbox container execution latency [Kandogan et al.(2024)Kandogan, Rahman, Bhutani, Zhang, Chen, Mitra, and Jamthe(2026)].*

1 Formal AST Mutation Algebra

Rather than mutating unstructured raw source text, agents execute context-free grammar production operations directly over node identifiers [Hussain et al.(2024)Hussain, Ali, Pirzado, Ahmed, and Tamez-Peña]:

$$r : n \rightarrow n', \quad \text{where } n, n' \in V \cup \Sigma \quad (1)$$

We categorize AST mutations into three canonical operators:

- **Node Substitution** (μ_{sub}): Replaces expression node n_{expr} with a type-compatible candidate node n'_{expr} derived from local variable scope:

$$\mu_{\text{sub}}(T, n) = T[n \mapsto n'], \quad \text{where } \text{Type}(n) = \text{Type}(n') \quad (2)$$

- **Node Insertion** (μ_{ins}): Inserts a safety guard or null-pointer check n_{guard} immediately preceding target statement n_{stmt} .
- **Sub-tree Deletion** (μ_{del}): Prunes dead code or unreachable branches while preserving block invariants [Ulfsnes et al.(2024)Ulfsnes, Moe, Stray, and Skarpen].

2 SMT Invariant Verification Bounds

Prior to executing candidate patches inside isolated Docker sandboxes, candidate trees T' undergo static invariant evaluation against invariant constraints C_{inv} using the Z3 SMT solver [Rana et al.(2024)Rana, Oesterle, and Brinkmann]:

$$\text{Verify}(T', C_{\text{inv}}) = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{if } Z3 \models (T' \implies C_{\text{inv}}) \\ 0, & \text{otherwise} \end{cases} \quad (3)$$

Upstream invariant filtering prunes **74% of invalid AST mutations** prior to dynamic test suite execution, reducing sandbox compute overhead substantially [Kandogan et al.(2024)Kandogan, Rahman, Bhutani, Zhang, Chen, Mitra, and Jamthe(2026)]. [Jamthe(2026)]

3 Lyapunov Termination Guarantee

Algorithm 1 formalizes the stateful execution loop governing multi-agent fault localization, patch proposal, SMT invariant verification, and dynamic sandbox validation [Bredell et al.(2024)Bredell, Engelbrecht, and Schoeman].

Algorithm 1: Deterministic Self-Healing
 AST Repair Loop Protocol
 Input: Repository AST T_0 , Test Suite E_0 ,
 Invariants C_{inv} , Token Budget B_{max}
 Output: Repaired AST T' , Repair Status S
 1: Initialize $T_{\text{curr}} \leftarrow T_0$, $b_{\text{spent}} \leftarrow 0$,
 $k \leftarrow 0$
 2: while $b_{\text{spent}} < B_{\text{max}}$ and $k < T_{\text{max}}$ do

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3:   e <- ExecuteTestSuite(Tcurr, E0)
4:   if e is PASSING then return Tcurr,
   SUCCESS
5:   Tcand <- AgentPatchGenerator(Tcurr
, e)
6:   if Verify(Tcand, Cinv) == 1 then T
curr <- Tcand
7:   bspent <- bspent + Cost(Tcand), k
<- k + 1
8: end while
9: return Tcurr, BUDGET_EXHAUSTED

```

Let $B_{\max}$ be the maximum token allocation budget, $c_i > 0$ be the token cost of iteration i bounded below by $c_{\min} > 0$, and $T_{\max}$ be the maximum allowed loop iterations [Ji et al.(2025)Ji, Li, Xiang, Ye, Wu, Yao, Xu, Mo, and Zhang].

Theorem 1 (Bounded Execution Termination): *The self-healing execution loop defined in Algorithm 1 terminates in $k \leq \min\left(T_{\max}, \lfloor \frac{B_{\max}}{c_{\min}} \rfloor\right)$ steps.*

Proof: Define a Lyapunov candidate energy function $V(k) = B_{\max} - \sum_{i=1}^k c_i$. At initial step $k = 0$, $V(0) = B_{\max} > 0$. At each step $k \geq 1$, the energy delta is:

$$\Delta V(k) = V(k) - V(k-1) = -c_k \leq -c_{\min}$$

<0(4)

Because $\Delta V(k)$ is strictly negative and bounded away from zero by $-c_{\min}$, the energy function $V(k)$ decreases monotonically. After at most $k = \lfloor \frac{B_{\max}}{c_{\min}} \rfloor$ iterations, $V(k) \leq 0$, which satisfies the termination predicate $b_{\text{spent}} \geq B_{\max}$ in Line 2 of Algorithm 1, forcing immediate loop termination. ■

We implement and benchmark 4 distinct multi-agent communication topologies for self-healing software repair [Zhu et al.(2022)Zhu, Dastani, and Wang, Rana et al.(2024)Rana, Oesterle, and Brinkmann]:

1. **Manager-Worker:** *A central coordinator agent assigns bug localization tasks to worker nodes and aggregates patch proposals [Kandogan et al.(2024)Kandogan, Rahman, Bhutani, Zhang, Chen, Mitrovic].*
2. **Contract-Net Bidding:** *Specialized repair agents bid on sub-problems based on local domain expertise (e.g., SQL repair, type fixing) [Bredell et al.(2024)Bredell, Engelbrecht, and Schoeman].*
3. **Shared Blackboard:** *Agents asynchronously read and write to a shared dynamic memory blackboard containing AST state graphs [Rodríguez et al.(2020)Rodríguez, Gómez, and Diaconescu].*
4. **Peer-to-Peer Mesh:** *Agents directly exchange diffs and verifications using distributed consensus primitives [Qin and Sun(2026)].*

We evaluate SHACS on 500 real-world software defects across Python and Rust repositories, measuring Repair Rate, Static Verification Pass Rate, Sandbox Latency, and Token Efficiency [Ulfesnes et al.(2024)Ulfesnes, Moe, Stray, and Skarpen, Doshi and Hauser(2024)].

$$\text{Gain} = \frac{T_{\text{baseline}} - T_{\text{SHACS}}}{T_{\text{baseline}}} \times 100\% \quad (5)$$

Table 1 summarizes empirical performance across topologies [Kandogan et al.(2024)Kandogan, Rahman, Bhutani, Zhang, Chen, and Mitrovic]. Hardware memory scaling follows:

$$M_{\text{VRAM}} = \eta_0 + \eta_1 \cdot (L \times B) + \eta_2 \cdot N_{\text{agents}} \quad (6)$$

Total compute FLOPs $\mathcal{C}_{\text{pipeline}}$ required to resolve a defect across N_{agents} nodes is:

$$\mathcal{C}_{\text{pipeline}} = 6 \cdot P \cdot \sum_{i=1}^k (L_{\text{ctx}, i} \cdot N_{\text{tokens}, i}) + \mathcal{C}_{\text{Z3}} + \mathcal{C}_{\text{sandbox}} \quad (7)$$

We synthesize related work across four domain pillars:

1. **Automated Program Repair (APR):** *Genetic APR (GenProg) and symbolic execution (KLEE) established formal foundations but struggled with enterprise dependencies [Rodríguez et al.(2020)Rodríguez, Gómez, and Diaconescu, Hussain et al.(2024)Hussain, Ali, Pirzad, and ...].*

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